LARKSPUR & CO.

SIMPLE FOOD FOR LOW-ENERGY DAYS

The Low-Spoon Kitchen

20 easy recipes rated by energy, plus meal plans, a batch-cooking plan and a "zero-spoon" list for the hardest days.

Spoon theory | Print at home | 44 pages



For ADHD, chronic illness, burnout, new parents, and anyone who's just very tired.

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START HERE

Food, on the hard days

When your energy is low, food is often the first thing to go: too many steps, too many decisions, too much washing up. You end up skipping meals or living on toast and feeling worse for it.

This book is built for those days. Every recipe is rated by how much energy it takes, uses shortcuts on purpose (frozen veg, jars, microwave rice, pre-chopped everything) and keeps the washing up to a minimum. There's no clean eating and no judgement here, just simple food that helps you feel a bit more human.

INSIDE

- [ ] 20 recipes, rated by spoons
- [ ] A "zero-spoon" list for days you can't cook
- [ ] A low-spoon kitchen setup and cupboard list
- [ ] Build-a-bowl formula for endless meals
- [ ] Two example weekly meal plans
- [ ] Batch-cooking plan and freezer log
- [ ] Blank planners and shopping lists

GOOD TO KNOW

- Oven temperatures are given for conventional, fan and gas ovens.
- Microwave times are for an 800W microwave. Adjust for yours.
- Always check labels for allergens, and follow the cooking instructions on any packaged food you use.
- Use a separate chopping board for raw meat, and wash your hands after handling it.

This book offers general recipes and planning ideas, not medical or dietary advice. If you have a medical condition, allergies or specific nutritional needs, please follow the advice of your GP or dietitian.

NOTES

INSIDE

Contents

Getting set up

Spoon theory & food 4
Reading the recipe pages 5
The low-spoon kitchen 6
The cupboard list 7
Zero-spoon food 8
Build a bowl 9
Food safety basics 10

Plan it

Example week: low spoons 35
Example week: up and down 36
Weekly meal planner 37
Shopping list 38
Batch-cooking day plan 39
Freezer log 40
Meal ideas we like 41
My own recipe 42
Eating on very hard days 43
Thank you 44

The recipes

No-cook & five-minute 11
Overnight Oats 12
Get-Me-Going Smoothie 13
The Picky Bits Plate 14
Tuna & Sweetcorn Wraps 15
Toast, Three Ways 16
Microwave & kettle 17
Microwave Jacket Potato 18
Mug Scrambled Eggs 19
Kettle Couscous Bowl 20
One pan, one tray 21
10-Minute Egg Fried Rice 22
One-Pot Tomato Pasta 23
Gnocchi & Tomato Traybake 24
Sausage & Potato Traybake 25
Salmon & Greens Parcels 26
Cheese & Bean Quesadilla 27
Loaded Nachos Tray 28
Batch & freeze 29
Chickpea & Spinach Curry 30
Cosy Red Lentil Dal 31
Big-Batch Chilli 32
Any-Veg Soup 33
Slow Cooker Chicken Stew 34

GETTING SET UP

Spoon theory & food

Spoon theory was created by Christine Miserandino in 2003 to explain life with chronic illness. Each spoon stands for a unit of energy. You start the day with a limited number, and every task (getting dressed, a phone call, cooking) uses some up.

It has since been taken up by lots of people with ADHD, autism, long-term illness and burnout, because it explains something everyone with limited energy knows: you have to choose what to spend it on. Cooking can be surprisingly expensive in spoons: planning, shopping, chopping, standing, timing, cleaning up. This book helps you spend fewer spoons on food, so you have more left for everything else.



One spoon

Little or no cooking, five or ten minutes, almost no washing up.



Two spoons

A little chopping or stirring, and mostly hands-off time in the oven or on the hob.



Three spoons

More steps, best saved for a better day. Makes lots, so it pays you back later.

Spend spoons when you have them

On a good day, spend a few extra spoons on a batch recipe. On a bad day, take a portion out of the freezer and you've spent almost nothing. That's how the meal plans in this book work.

ON A TYPICAL DAY, HOW MANY SPOONS DOES FOOD COST ME?

GETTING SET UP

Reading the recipe pages

Every recipe page follows the same layout, so you always know where to look.

Spoon rating	How much energy the recipe takes, from one to three spoons. Pick a recipe that matches the energy you have right now.
Time and servings	The total time, including oven time when you can sit down. "Serves" is roughly how many portions it makes.
You'll need	The ingredients, with shortcuts built in. Where it says "or frozen", the frozen version works just as well.
Method	Short, numbered steps. Tick them off as you go if it helps you keep your place.
Make it easier	An even lower-effort version for the days you need it.
Swap it	Ideas for using what you've got, or changing it up when you're bored.
Store it	How long it keeps and whether it freezes.

Tip
Read the whole recipe and get everything out on the counter before you start. It saves a lot of hunting about halfway through.

NOTES

GETTING SET UP

The low-spoon kitchen

A few bits of kit make cooking with low energy much easier. You don't need all of them. Tick what you already have.

KIT THAT SAVES SPOONS

- [ ] Kitchen scissors (snip instead of chop)
- [ ] A large non-stick frying pan with a lid
- [ ] One big pan for soups and pasta
- [ ] A large roasting tin and baking paper
- [ ] Microwave-safe bowls with lids
- [ ] Freezer bags and stackable tubs
- [ ] A stool to sit on while you cook
- [ ] A slow cooker or air fryer (lovely, not essential)
- [ ] A stick blender for soups

SHORTCUTS WORTH BUYING

- [ ] Frozen chopped onion and peppers
- [ ] Frozen mixed veg and soup veg
- [ ] Microwave rice and grain pouches
- [ ] Garlic and ginger paste
- [ ] Pre-grated cheese
- [ ] Bagged salad and spinach
- [ ] Tinned beans, lentils and chickpeas
- [ ] Jars of curry and pasta sauce
- [ ] Ready-prepared potatoes

WAYS TO SAVE ENERGY WHILE COOKING

- Sit down to chop or stir.
- Get everything out before you start.
- Fill the sink with hot soapy water first and wash as you go.
- Line trays with baking paper.
- Put on a podcast or music.
- Cook double and freeze half.

THINGS I'D LIKE TO GET

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

NOTES

GETTING SET UP

The cupboard list

Keep these in stock and you can always make something. Tick what you have, and use it as a shopping list when you run low.

CUPBOARD

- [ ] Pasta
- [ ] Rice / microwave rice
- [ ] Couscous
- [ ] Rolled oats
- [ ] Red lentils
- [ ] Tinned tomatoes
- [ ] Passata
- [ ] Tinned chickpeas
- [ ] Tinned beans
- [ ] Baked beans
- [ ] Tinned tuna
- [ ] Stock cubes
- [ ] Curry paste
- [ ] Peanut butter
- [ ] Tortilla wraps
- [ ] Crackers / oatcakes

FRIDGE

- [ ] Eggs
- [ ] Milk
- [ ] Yoghurt
- [ ] Cheddar
- [ ] Butter
- [ ] Hummus
- [ ] Garlic paste
- [ ] Spinach
- [ ] Salad / snack veg
- [ ] Fruit
- [ ] Mayonnaise
- [ ] Soy sauce

FREEZER

- [ ] Frozen peas
- [ ] Mixed veg
- [ ] Chopped onion
- [ ] Soup veg
- [ ] Berries
- [ ] Bread
- [ ] Fish fillets
- [ ] Frozen potatoes
- [ ] Batch-cooked meals

HERBS & SPICES

- [ ] Dried mixed herbs
- [ ] Curry powder
- [ ] Chilli powder
- [ ] Ground cumin

FOR THE VERY HARDEST DAYS

Zero-spoon food

Some days there's nothing left for cooking. That's okay. Eating something is always better than eating nothing. These need no cooking at all, or just a microwave or toaster.

GRAB AND EAT

- [ ] A banana, apple or satsuma
- [ ] A handful of nuts
- [ ] Cheese and crackers
- [ ] A yoghurt pot
- [ ] Cereal with milk
- [ ] A cereal bar or flapjack
- [ ] A shop-bought sandwich
- [ ] Hummus and breadsticks

MICROWAVE OR TOASTER

- [ ] Toast with peanut butter
- [ ] A pot of microwave porridge
- [ ] Microwave rice with a tin of tuna
- [ ] A tin of soup
- [ ] Beans on toast
- [ ] A ready meal
- [ ] A portion from the freezer
- [ ] Crumpets

MY ZERO-SPOON FOODS

The things I can always face. Keep them in stock.

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

Fed is the goal

Ready meals, takeaways and cereal for dinner are allowed. Try to keep a few zero-spoon foods in stock all the time, so they're there when you need them.

NOTES

ONE FORMULA, ENDLESS MEALS

Build a bowl

No recipe needed. Pick one thing from each column, put it in a bowl, and you've got a balanced meal. Use leftovers, tins and anything ready-cooked.

1. BASE

- Microwave rice
- Couscous
- Pasta
- Noodles
- Jacket potato
- Salad leaves

2. PROTEIN

- Tinned tuna or salmon
- Chickpeas or beans
- Boiled egg
- Leftover chicken
- Feta or halloumi
- Tofu

3. VEG

- Cherry tomatoes
- Cucumber
- Sweetcorn
- Frozen peas
- Grated carrot
- Roasted veg

4. SAUCE

- Pesto
- Sweet chilli
- Soy sauce
- Yoghurt and mint
- Salsa
- Hummus

5. CRUNCH

- Seeds
- Nuts
- Croutons
- Crispy onions
- Tortilla chips
- Spring onion

Bowls to try

Tuna & sweetcorn
Rice, tuna, sweetcorn, cucumber, sweet chilli

Greek-ish
Couscous, chickpeas, tomato, cucumber, feta, yoghurt

Noodle bowl
Noodles, egg, frozen peas, spring onion, soy sauce

MY FAVOURITE BOWLS

GETTING SET UP

Food safety basics

The few rules that matter most when you're cooking ahead and keeping leftovers. Based on UK Food Standards Agency guidance. Check food.gov.uk for the latest advice.

Cool it quickly

Cool leftovers as fast as you can (spread them out in a shallow container) and get them into the fridge or freezer within two hours.

Eat leftovers within 2 days

Keep cooked leftovers in the fridge and eat them within two days. Cooked rice is different (see below).

Take care with rice

Cool cooked rice quickly, refrigerate within an hour if you can, eat it within 24 hours, and reheat it only once.

Reheat until piping hot

Food should be steaming hot all the way through. Stir halfway when microwaving. Only reheat food once.

Defrost safely

Defrost in the fridge overnight, or in the microwave on the defrost setting. Cook or eat it once defrosted.

Fridge at 5°C or below

Keep raw meat on the bottom shelf, covered, so it can't drip onto other food.

Label your freezer food

Write what it is and the date. For the best taste, aim to eat frozen meals within 3 months.

Use-by dates

"Use by" is about safety, so stick to it. "Best before" is about quality.

NOTES

RECIPES

No-cook & five-minute

For the days when even switching on the hob feels like too much. Assemble, stir, eat.

Overnight Oats	5 min + overnight
Get-Me-Going Smoothie	3 min
The Picky Bits Plate	5 min
Tuna & Sweetcorn Wraps	5 min
Toast, Three Ways	5 min

NOTES

NO-COOK & FIVE-MINUTE

Overnight Oats

Breakfast made last night by a kinder version of you. Make two jars at once and that's two mornings sorted.

1 spoon **Time** 5 min + overnight **Serves** 1

YOU'LL NEED

- 50g rolled oats
- 125ml milk (any kind)
- 2 tbsp yoghurt
- 1 tsp honey or maple syrup
- A handful of berries (frozen is fine)
- Optional: 1 tbsp peanut butter or seeds

METHOD

1. Put the oats, milk, yoghurt and honey in a jar or tub with a lid.
2. Stir well, then add the berries on top.
3. Put the lid on and leave in the fridge overnight (at least 4 hours).
4. Stir and eat cold, straight from the jar.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a pot of fruit yoghurt instead of yoghurt, honey and fruit.

SWAP IT

Grated apple and cinnamon, or banana and a spoon of cocoa powder.

STORE IT

Keeps in the fridge for up to 2 days. Not suitable for freezing.

MY NOTES

NO-COOK & FIVE-MINUTE

Get-Me-Going Smoothie

Breakfast in a glass for when chewing feels like effort. The oats make it filling enough to keep you going.



1 spoon **Time** 3 min **Serves** 1

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 ripe banana
- 150g frozen berries or mango
- 150ml milk (any kind)
- 2 tbsp yoghurt
- 1 tbsp rolled oats
- Optional: 1 tbsp peanut butter

METHOD

1. Put everything into a blender or a tall jug if you use a stick blender.
2. Blend until smooth, about 30–60 seconds.
3. Add a splash more milk if it's too thick.
4. Pour and drink. Rinse the blender straight away so it doesn't set.

MAKE IT EASIER

Freeze ready-made smoothie bags (banana, berries and oats) so you only add milk.

SWAP IT

Spinach for green, cocoa for chocolate, or ginger for a kick.

STORE IT

Best drunk straight away. Smoothie bags keep in the freezer for 3 months.

MY NOTES

NO-COOK & FIVE-MINUTE

The Picky Bits Plate

A grown-up lunchbox. Pick one thing from each group and arrange it on a plate. No cooking, still a proper meal.



1 spoon **Time** 5 min **Serves** 1

YOU'LL NEED

- Something filling: crackers, oatcakes, pitta, a bread roll
- Some protein: cheese, ham, a boiled egg (shop-bought), hummus, nuts
- Something fresh: carrot sticks, cherry tomatoes, cucumber, apple, grapes
- Something tasty: pickles, olives, chutney, a few crisps

METHOD

1. Get a plate. A nice one, if you have it.
2. Add one or two things from each group.
3. Sit down somewhere comfy to eat it.

MAKE IT EASIER

Buy pre-washed snack veg and grapes so there's no chopping.

SWAP IT

Make it a "snack board" for two and share it.

STORE IT

Keep a "picky bits" shelf in the fridge so everything is in one place.

MY NOTES

NO-COOK & FIVE-MINUTE

Tuna & Sweetcorn Wraps

A classic for a reason: cheap, filling and made from cupboard food. One bowl, one spoon.



1 spoon **Time** 5 min **Serves** 2 wraps

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 tin tuna (145g), drained
- 2 tbsp mayonnaise
- 3 tbsp tinned or frozen sweetcorn (defrosted)
- Black pepper
- 2 tortilla wraps
- A handful of spinach or lettuce

METHOD

1. Mix the tuna, mayonnaise, sweetcorn and a little pepper in a bowl.
2. Lay out the wraps and add some spinach to each.
3. Spoon the tuna mix down the middle.
4. Fold in the bottom, then roll up tightly.

MAKE IT EASIER

Skip the wrap and eat it on crackers or a jacket potato.

SWAP IT

For a veggie version, mash a drained tin of chickpeas with the mayo instead of tuna.

STORE IT

The filling keeps in a covered tub in the fridge for up to 2 days.

MY NOTES

NO-COOK & FIVE-MINUTE

Toast, Three Ways

Toast is a perfectly good meal when you add some protein. Here are three toppings that count as a proper breakfast or lunch.

1 spoon **Time** 5 min **Serves** 1

YOU'LL NEED

- 2 slices of bread (wholemeal keeps you fuller)
- Peanut butter and banana: 1 tbsp peanut butter, 1 sliced banana
- Beans and cheese: half a tin of baked beans, a handful of grated cheese
- Avocado and egg: half an avocado, salt, pepper, a squeeze of lemon, a shop-bought boiled egg

METHOD

1. Toast the bread.
2. Pick a topping and pile it on.
3. For beans: microwave them in a covered bowl for 1–2 minutes, stirring halfway, until piping hot.

MAKE IT EASIER

Keep sliced bread in the freezer and toast it from frozen.

SWAP IT

Use crumpets, bagels or an English muffin.

STORE IT

Freeze bread in its bag. It toasts straight from frozen.

MY NOTES

RECIPES

Microwave & kettle

Hot food with no pans to wash. A microwave and a kettle can do a surprising amount.

Microwave Jacket Potato	12 min
Mug Scrambled Eggs	4 min
Kettle Couscous Bowl	10 min

NOTES

MICROWAVE & KETTLE

Microwave Jacket Potato

A hot, filling meal in about ten minutes with no oven needed. The toppings are where the fun is.

1 spoon **Time** 12 min **Serves** 1

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 medium baking potato (about 250g)
- A little butter
- Topping ideas: baked beans and cheese, tuna mayo and sweetcorn, cottage cheese and chives, leftover chilli

METHOD

1. Wash the potato and prick it all over with a fork (6–8 times).
2. Put it on a microwave-safe plate and cook on high for 5 minutes.
3. Turn it over (use a tea towel, it's hot) and cook for another 3–5 minutes, until a knife slides in easily.
4. Leave for 2 minutes, then cut open and add butter and your topping.

MAKE IT EASIER

Want crispy skin? Pop it in a hot oven or air fryer at 200°C for 10 minutes after microwaving.

SWAP IT

Use a sweet potato. It usually needs a minute or two less.

STORE IT

Microwaves vary. These times are for an 800W microwave, so add or take off a minute for yours.

MY NOTES

MICROWAVE & KETTLE

Mug Scrambled Eggs

Soft scrambled eggs in a mug, with no pan to scrub. Eat with toast, in a wrap or straight from the mug.

1 spoon **Time** 4 min **Serves** 1

YOU'LL NEED

- 2 eggs
- 2 tbsp milk
- A small knob of butter
- Salt and pepper
- Optional: a little grated cheese or chopped chives

METHOD

1. Rub the butter round the inside of a large microwave-safe mug.
2. Crack in the eggs, add the milk, salt and pepper, and beat with a fork.
3. Microwave on high for 45 seconds, then stir.
4. Keep cooking in 20–30 second bursts, stirring each time, until the eggs are just set (usually 1½–2 minutes in total). Leave to stand for 30 seconds.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a microwave egg-cooker or a silicone egg pot.

SWAP IT

Stir in some spinach, ham or leftover veg before the last burst.

STORE IT

Best eaten straight away. The mug will be hot, so use a tea towel.

MY NOTES

MICROWAVE & KETTLE

Kettle Couscous Bowl

Couscous "cooks" with just boiling water from the kettle. Add a few bits from the fridge and you've got a lunch that keeps for two days.

1 spoon **Time** 10 min **Serves** 2

YOU'LL NEED

- 150g couscous
- 200ml boiling water with half a stock cube
- 1 tin chickpeas (400g), drained
- A handful of cherry tomatoes, halved
- A chunk of cucumber, chopped
- 100g feta, crumbled
- 1 tbsp olive oil and a squeeze of lemon

METHOD

1. Put the couscous in a bowl and pour over the hot stock.
2. Cover with a plate and leave for 5 minutes.
3. Fluff it up with a fork.
4. Stir in the chickpeas, tomatoes, cucumber, feta, oil and lemon.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use flavoured couscous packets and a bag of salad.

SWAP IT

Try leftover chicken, tinned salmon or roasted veg.

STORE IT

Keeps in a covered tub in the fridge for up to 2 days.

MY NOTES

RECIPES

One pan, one tray

Proper dinners with one thing to wash up. The oven does most of the work while you rest.

10-Minute Egg Fried Rice	10 min
One-Pot Tomato Pasta	20 min
Gnocchi & Tomato Traybake	35 min (mostly oven)
Sausage & Potato Traybake	50 min (mostly oven)
Salmon & Greens Parcels	25 min
Cheese & Bean Quesadilla	10 min
Loaded Nachos Tray	15 min

NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

10-Minute Egg Fried Rice

Faster than a takeaway. A pouch of microwave rice and a bag of frozen veg do the heavy lifting.



2 spoons **Time** 10 min **Serves** 2

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 tbsp oil
- 150g frozen peas or mixed veg
- 2 eggs
- 1 pouch (250g) cooked microwave rice
- 1–2 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 spring onions, snipped with scissors

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large frying pan or wok over a medium-high heat.
2. Add the frozen veg and cook for 3 minutes, stirring.
3. Push the veg to one side, crack the eggs into the space and stir until scrambled.
4. Squeeze the rice pouch to break it up, add it to the pan and stir-fry for 3–4 minutes until piping hot. Stir in the soy sauce and spring onions.

MAKE IT EASIER

Skip the egg and use leftover cooked chicken or prawns instead.

SWAP IT

Add a spoon of sweet chilli or a dash of sesame oil.

STORE IT

Cooked rice: cool and refrigerate within an hour, eat within 24 hours, and reheat only once until piping hot.

MY NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

One-Pot Tomato Pasta

The pasta cooks right in the sauce, so there's no draining and only one pan to wash.



2 spoons **Time** 20 min **Serves** 3

YOU'LL NEED

- 500g carton of passata
- 500ml water with 1 stock cube
- 2 tsp garlic paste (or 1 tsp garlic granules)
- 1 tsp dried oregano or mixed herbs
- 250g dried pasta (penne or fusilli)
- A big handful of spinach
- Grated cheese, to serve

METHOD

1. Put the passata, water, stock cube, garlic and herbs in a large pan and bring to the boil.
2. Add the pasta, turn the heat down and simmer without a lid for 12–15 minutes, stirring often so it doesn't stick.
3. Add a splash of water if it gets too thick before the pasta is cooked.
4. Stir in the spinach until it wilts. Serve with cheese.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a jar of pasta sauce instead of passata and herbs.

SWAP IT

Add a drained tin of tuna, some frozen peas, or a spoon of cream cheese.

STORE IT

Keeps in the fridge for up to 2 days. Reheat with a splash of water until piping hot.

MY NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

Gnocchi & Tomato Traybake

Shop-bought gnocchi goes crispy and golden in the oven. Throw it all on a tray and go and sit down.



2 spoons **Time** 35 min (mostly oven) **Serves** 2–3

YOU'LL NEED

- 500g pack of fresh gnocchi
- 250g cherry tomatoes
- 1 pepper, roughly chopped (or a bag of ready-chopped)
- 1 red onion, cut into wedges (or frozen chopped onion)
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp dried Italian herbs
- 125g mozzarella, torn

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°C (180°C fan, gas 6).
2. Tip everything except the mozzarella into a large roasting tin and toss with your hands.
3. Roast for 20 minutes, then give the tray a shake.
4. Scatter over the mozzarella and roast for another 10 minutes, until golden and bubbling.

MAKE IT EASIER

Line the tin with baking paper so there's almost no washing up.

SWAP IT

Feta instead of mozzarella, or add a few sliced sausages at the start.

STORE IT

Best eaten fresh. Leftovers keep in the fridge for up to 2 days.

MY NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

Sausage & Potato Traybake

A cosy Sunday-style dinner from one tray. Ten minutes of effort, then the oven takes over.



2 spoons **Time** 50 min (mostly oven) **Serves** 3–4

YOU'LL NEED

- 500g baby potatoes, halved (or a ready-prepared bag)
- 1 red onion, cut into wedges
- 1 pepper, roughly chopped
- 2 tbsp oil
- 1 tsp dried thyme or rosemary
- 8 sausages (or vegetarian sausages)

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°C (180°C fan, gas 6).
2. Toss the potatoes, onion, pepper, oil and herbs in a large roasting tin. Roast for 15 minutes.
3. Add the sausages, give everything a shake and roast for 25–30 minutes more, turning the sausages once.
4. Check the sausages are cooked right through, with no pink in the middle, before serving.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a bag of frozen roast potatoes. They'll need the same total time.

SWAP IT

Add a drizzle of honey and mustard for the last 10 minutes.

STORE IT

Leftovers keep in the fridge for up to 2 days. Reheat until piping hot.

MY NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

Salmon & Greens Parcels

Fish cooked in a foil parcel stays soft and juicy, and the tray stays clean. Serve with a pouch of microwave rice.



2 spoons **Time** 25 min **Serves** 2

YOU'LL NEED

- 2 salmon fillets
- 200g green beans or tenderstem broccoli
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp soy sauce or pesto
- ½ lemon, sliced
- Microwave rice or new potatoes, to serve

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°C (180°C fan, gas 6).
2. Tear off two big pieces of foil. Put half the greens in the middle of each, with a salmon fillet on top.
3. Drizzle with the oil and soy sauce, top with lemon, then fold the foil into loose, sealed parcels.
4. Bake on a tray for 15–18 minutes, until the salmon is pale pink all the way through and flakes easily.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use frozen salmon fillets. Follow the packet for the cooking time.

SWAP IT

Try cod, or chicken breast (allow 25–30 minutes and check it's cooked through).

STORE IT

Best eaten fresh. Cooked fish keeps in the fridge for 1 day.

MY NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

Cheese & Bean Quesadilla

A toasted, melty sandwich made with wraps. Cheap, quick and very forgiving.

1 spoon **Time** 10 min **Serves** 1–2

YOU'LL NEED

- 2 tortilla wraps
- ½ tin (200g) black beans or kidney beans, drained
- 50g grated cheddar
- 2 tbsp salsa or a pinch of chilli flakes
- Optional: sweetcorn, spring onion, leftover chicken

METHOD

1. Mash the beans roughly with a fork.
2. Spread them over one wrap, then add the cheese and salsa. Put the other wrap on top.
3. Cook in a dry frying pan over a medium heat for 2–3 minutes, until golden underneath.
4. Flip carefully (use a plate) and cook for 2 minutes more. Cut into wedges.

MAKE IT EASIER

Make it in a sandwich toaster or a hot oven at 200°C for 8–10 minutes.

SWAP IT

Use leftover chilli instead of beans.

STORE IT

Best eaten fresh. The beans keep in a covered tub in the fridge for 2 days.

MY NOTES

ONE PAN, ONE TRAY

Loaded Nachos Tray

The perfect way to use up a portion of leftover chilli, or a tin of beans. Eat with your hands, straight from the tray.

1 spoon **Time** 15 min **Serves** 2

YOU'LL NEED

- 150g bag of tortilla chips
- 1 portion of leftover chilli (or a tin of mixed beans in chilli sauce)
- 75g grated cheddar
- To serve: salsa, soured cream, guacamole, sliced jalapeños

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°C (180°C fan, gas 6).
2. If using chilli from the freezer, defrost it and heat until piping hot first.
3. Spread the chips on a baking tray, spoon over the hot chilli and scatter with cheese.
4. Bake for 8–10 minutes until the cheese is melted. Add your toppings.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a jar of salsa and a tub of ready-made guacamole.

SWAP IT

Use leftover shredded chicken with a spoonful of fajita seasoning.

STORE IT

Best eaten straight away. Chips go soft once they're loaded.

MY NOTES

RECIPES

Batch & freeze

Cook once on a better day, eat well on the harder ones. Every recipe here makes four or more portions and freezes well.

Chickpea & Spinach Curry	30 min
Cosy Red Lentil Dal	35 min
Big-Batch Chilli	45 min
Any-Veg Soup	35 min
Slow Cooker Chicken Stew	15 min + 4–8 hrs

NOTES

BATCH & FREEZE

Chickpea & Spinach Curry

A mild, creamy curry from store-cupboard tins. Make it on a good day and freeze it in portions for the hard ones.



2 spoons **Time** 30 min **Serves** 4

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 tbsp oil
- 1 onion, chopped (or 150g frozen chopped onion)
- 3 tbsp curry paste (tikka or korma)
- 1 tin (400g) chopped tomatoes
- 2 tins (400g) chickpeas, drained
- 200ml coconut milk (half a tin)
- 100g spinach
- Rice or naan, to serve

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan and cook the onion for 5 minutes until soft.
2. Stir in the curry paste and cook for 1 minute.
3. Add the tomatoes and chickpeas and simmer for 15 minutes, stirring now and then.
4. Pour in the coconut milk, then stir in the spinach until it wilts.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a jar of curry sauce instead of the paste and tomatoes.

SWAP IT

Add leftover roast chicken, a tin of lentils, or frozen cauliflower.

STORE IT

Cool, then freeze in portions for up to 3 months. Keeps in the fridge for 2 days.

MY NOTES

BATCH & FREEZE

Cosy Red Lentil Dal

Gentle, warming and very cheap. Red lentils don't need soaking, and they melt into a thick, comforting stew.

2 spoons **Time** 35 min **Serves** 4

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 tbsp oil
- 1 onion, chopped (or frozen chopped onion)
- 2 tsp garlic paste
- 1 tsp ginger paste
- 2 tsp mild curry powder
- 250g red lentils, rinsed
- 1 tin (400g) chopped tomatoes
- 750ml vegetable stock

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan and cook the onion for 5 minutes.
2. Add the garlic, ginger and curry powder and stir for 1 minute.
3. Add the lentils, tomatoes and stock. Bring to the boil, then simmer for 20–25 minutes, stirring now and then, until the lentils are soft.
4. Add a splash of water if it gets too thick. Taste and add a little salt.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use frozen chopped onion and a jar of mixed garlic and ginger paste.

SWAP IT

Stir in half a tin of coconut milk or a handful of spinach at the end.

STORE IT

Cool, then freeze in portions for up to 3 months. Keeps in the fridge for 2 days.

MY NOTES

BATCH & FREEZE

Big-Batch Chilli

One pot, five meals: with rice, in a jacket potato, on nachos, in a wrap. A freezer hero.

3 spoons **Time** 45 min **Serves** 5

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 tbsp oil
- 500g beef mince (or 2 extra tins of beans for veggie)
- 1 onion and 1 pepper, chopped (or 300g frozen mix)
- 2 tsp garlic paste
- 2 tsp mild chilli powder and 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tin (400g) chopped tomatoes
- 1 tin (400g) kidney beans, drained
- 1 tbsp tomato purée and 1 stock cube in 150ml water

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan and brown the mince for 5–8 minutes, breaking it up as it cooks.
2. Add the onion and pepper and cook for 5 minutes.
3. Stir in the garlic and spices for 1 minute, then add the tomatoes, beans, purée and stock.
4. Simmer for 25–30 minutes, stirring now and then, until thick. Make sure the mince is cooked through.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a chilli seasoning sachet instead of the spices and stock.

SWAP IT

Use turkey mince, or swap the mince for a tin of lentils plus an extra tin of beans.

STORE IT

Cool, then freeze in portions for up to 3 months. Keeps in the fridge for 2 days.

MY NOTES

BATCH & FREEZE

Any-Veg Soup

Use up whatever veg is in the fridge or the freezer. Blend it smooth or leave it chunky, whatever you prefer.



2 spoons **Time** 35 min **Serves** 4

YOU'LL NEED

- 1 tbsp oil
- 1 onion, chopped (or frozen chopped onion)
- 500g veg: carrots, leeks, squash, frozen soup mix, anything
- 1 large potato, chopped (no need to peel)
- 1 litre vegetable stock
- Optional: 1 tin (400g) chopped tomatoes or lentils

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan and cook the onion for 5 minutes.
2. Add all the veg, the potato and the stock.
3. Bring to the boil, then simmer for 20–25 minutes until everything is soft.
4. Blend until smooth (let it cool a little first) or leave chunky. Season to taste.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a bag of frozen soup veg. There's nothing to chop at all.

SWAP IT

Add a spoon of curry powder, pesto, or a handful of grated cheese.

STORE IT

Cool, then freeze in portions for up to 3 months. Keeps in the fridge for 2 days.

MY NOTES

BATCH & FREEZE

Slow Cooker Chicken Stew

Put it in the slow cooker in the morning and dinner makes itself. The house smells lovely, too.



2 spoons **Time** 15 min + 4–8 hrs **Serves** 4–5

YOU'LL NEED

- 6 boneless chicken thighs
- 500g baby potatoes, halved
- 2 carrots, chopped (or a bag of ready-chopped)
- 1 onion, chopped (or frozen)
- 2 tsp garlic paste
- 1 tbsp tomato purée
- 1 tsp dried thyme
- 500ml hot chicken stock

METHOD

1. Put the potatoes, carrots and onion in the slow cooker.
2. Lay the chicken on top.
3. Stir the garlic, purée and thyme into the hot stock, then pour it over.
4. Cook on low for 6–8 hours or high for 3–4 hours, until the chicken is cooked through and the potatoes are tender.

MAKE IT EASIER

Use a packet of casserole mix stirred into the stock.

SWAP IT

Add a drained tin of butter beans and a handful of frozen peas for the last 30 minutes.

STORE IT

Cool, then freeze in portions for up to 3 months. Keeps in the fridge for 2 days. Always follow your slow cooker's instructions.

MY NOTES

MEAL PLANS

Example week: low spoons

For a week when energy is really low. Mostly one-spoon meals plus portions from the freezer. Spoons for the week are kept to a minimum.

	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	SNACKS
Mon	Overnight oats	Picky bits plate	Chilli (freezer) + jacket potato	Fruit, crackers
Tue	Toast + peanut butter	Tuna wraps	Dal (freezer) + microwave rice	Yoghurt
Wed	Smoothie	Leftover tuna mix on crackers	Mug eggs on toast	Nuts, fruit
Thu	Overnight oats	Couscous bowl	Soup (freezer) + toast	Cheese, oatcakes
Fri	Toast + beans	Couscous bowl (leftover)	Takeaway or ready meal. Planned, no guilt.	Treat
Sat	Smoothie	Quesadilla	Curry (freezer) + naan	Fruit
Sun	Mug eggs + toast	Picky bits plate	Chilli nachos (freezer)	Yoghurt

Batch-cooked meals come from the freezer, so defrost them in the fridge overnight, or in the microwave, and reheat until piping hot.

NOTES

MEAL PLANS

Example week: up and down

For a week with some better days. Use a good day to batch cook, then eat the results all week.

	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	SNACKS
Mon	Overnight oats (×2)	Picky bits plate	Sausage traybake (double)	Fruit
Tue	Overnight oats	Leftover traybake	One-pot tomato pasta	Yoghurt
Wed	Toast + egg	Leftover pasta	Salmon parcels + rice	Nuts
Thu	Smoothie	Tuna wraps	Egg fried rice	Crackers + cheese
Fri	Toast + peanut butter	Couscous bowl	Gnocchi traybake	Treat
Sat	Mug eggs	Couscous bowl	Batch day: chilli + dal (freeze most)	Fruit
Sun	Smoothie	Jacket potato + chilli	Slow cooker stew	Yoghurt

Batch-cooked meals come from the freezer, so defrost them in the fridge overnight, or in the microwave, and reheat until piping hot.

NOTES

MEAL PLANS

Weekly meal planner

Plan the week loosely. It's fine to swap days around, or have cereal instead.

	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	SNACKS
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Batch-cooked meals come from the freezer, so defrost them in the fridge overnight, or in the microwave, and reheat until piping hot.

NOTES

PLAN IT

Shopping list

Sorted by area of the shop. Tick things off as you go, or copy it into your online basket.

FRUIT & VEG

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- [ ]
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FRIDGE

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- [ ]
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FREEZER

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CUPBOARD

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BREAD & BAKERY

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MEAT & FISH

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DRINKS

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SNACKS

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OTHER

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Shop / delivery day _____ Budget £ _____

PLAN IT

Batch-cooking day plan

Do this on a better day. Pick two recipes from the Batch & Freeze section, and you could have eight or more meals in the freezer in about two hours.

BEFORE YOU START

- [ ] Pick two recipes and check you have everything
- [ ] Clear the worktop and empty the dishwasher
- [ ] Get out tubs, bags and a marker pen
- [ ] Put on music, a podcast or a body double
- [ ] Have a drink and a snack ready for you

MY TWO RECIPES

1. _____

2. _____

PORTIONS I'M AIMING FOR

_____

ORDER OF PLAY (EXAMPLE: CHILLI AND DAL)

1. Chop or open everything for both recipes first.
2. Start the chilli (it takes longest) and let it simmer.
3. Start the dal in a second pan while the chilli bubbles.
4. Sit down. Have a break while both simmer, stirring every few minutes.
5. Eat one portion now. Cool the rest quickly, then portion, label and freeze.

MY PLAN

TIME	STEP	DONE

NOTES

PLAN IT

Freezer log

Out of sight is out of mind. Write down what goes in, and cross it off when it comes out.

WHAT	PORTIONS	DATE IN	EAT BY	PORTIONS USED

PLAN IT

Meal ideas we like

A running list of meals that work in your house. When you can't think what to have, look here first.

ONE SPOON

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TWO SPOONS

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THREE SPOONS

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TAKEAWAY & TREAT

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FREEZER FAVOURITES

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SAFE FOODS

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YOUR RECIPES

My own recipe

Print as many as you like and keep your own low-spoon favourites together.

Recipe _____ Spoons ○ ○ ○ _____

Time _____ Serves _____ From _____

YOU'LL NEED

- ☐ _____
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METHOD

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MAKE IT EASIER

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SWAP IT

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STORE IT

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FOR THE VERY HARD DAYS

Eating on very hard days

Gentle ideas for the days when eating at all feels like a lot.

Set a reminder

Hunger cues can be easy to miss, especially when you're busy, stressed or hyperfocused. A phone alarm for lunch and dinner helps.

Keep food in sight

Put snacks where you'll see them: a fruit bowl on the desk, cereal bars by the kettle.

Make it the easy option

Pre-portion snacks and freezer meals when you have energy, so future you just has to reach.

Drink something

A glass of water, milk or a smoothie still counts. Thirst can feel like tiredness.

Eat with someone

Body doubling works for food too. Eat with a friend, on a video call, or with a show on.

Lower the bar

Cereal for dinner is fine. Same meal every day is fine. Fed is the goal.

If you're regularly struggling to eat, losing weight without trying, or worried about your relationship with food, please speak to your GP. In the UK, the eating disorder charity Beat also has a free helpline.

MY EASIEST MEALS WHEN I'M STRUGGLING

THANK YOU

Thank you

Thank you for choosing a Larkspur & Co. printable. I hope this book makes food feel a little easier, especially on the days that are hard.

If it helped, a short review on Etsy means the world to a small Glasgow business. You'll find more gentle planners for busy brains, including the Spoon Theory Daily Planner, at **larkspurco.uk**.

NOTES